SPOTTING TRUSTWORTHY INFORMATION

A Practical Guide for Navigating Today's Media

Welcome!

Today’s goals:

- Identify trustworthy UK news sources
- Learn practical fact-checking techniques
- Protect yourself from scams
- Build confidence in spotting misinformation

What Are We Talking About?

Misinformation: False information shared without **intent** to harm (mistakes, misunderstandings)

Disinformation: False information **deliberately** created to deceive or manipulate

Fake News: Fabricated stories designed to **look like** real **news** articles

The Impact of Misinformation

Misinformation affects:

- Your health decisions
- Your finances and savings
- Your vote and civic participation
- Your relationships with family and friends
- Your trust in institutions

Everyone is Vulnerable

- 90% of UK adults have encountered false information online, with 4 in 10 UK adults encountering misinformation in a single month according to Ofcom!
- Sadly, older adults are specifically targeted by scammers
- Even experts can be fooled
- But, good news! Skills can be learned

Understanding Trustworthy (UK) Sources

What makes a source reliable?

Trusted UK News Organisations

Broadcasters:

- BBC
- ITV News
- Channel 4 News
- Sky News

Major National Newspapers:

- The Times / The Sunday Times
- The Guardian / The Observer
- The Telegraph
- Financial Times
- The Independent

Important Distinction

Bias: A particular perspective or political leaning

- Newspapers that have bias aren't automatically misinformation – can still be factually accurate (Altay, 2023)
- Some present more politically aligned content

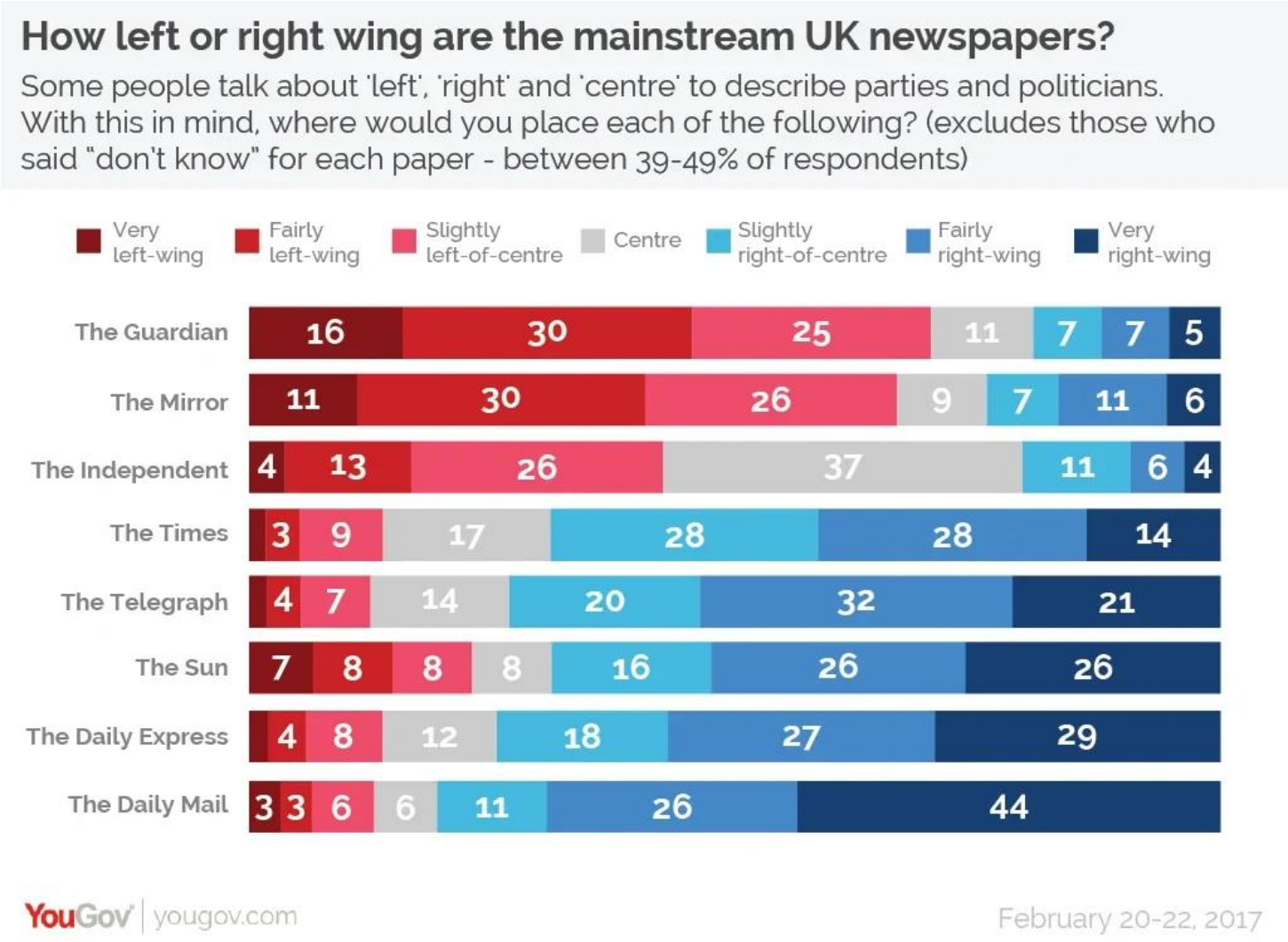


Image credit: YouGov

Important Distinction

Unreliability: Consistently publishing false or misleading information

- Not the same as bias

Image Credit: Newsround

So, Who Keeps an Eye on the News?

ISPO (Independent Press Standards Organisation)

- Regulates newspapers and magazines (print media)
- Handles complaints about accuracy

Ofcom

- Regulates TV and radio broadcasters
- Ensures impartiality in news

The public can complain to ISPO or Ofcom if you spot serious issues in news content.

Red Flags for Fake News Sites

Warning Signs:

✗ URL mimics real news (e.g., "bbc-news-daily.com" instead of "bbc.co.uk")

✗ Excessive spelling or grammar errors

✗ No "About Us" page or contact information

✗ Sensational headlines that don't match the story

✗ No author name or credentials

✗ Lots of pop-up ads

✗ "Share before it's taken down!" urgency

Fake News can also be Scams

Common UK Scam Pattern

Fake news article claims:

- Martin Lewis endorses investment scheme
- Deborah Meaden backs new business opportunity
- Holly Willoughby promotes weight loss pills

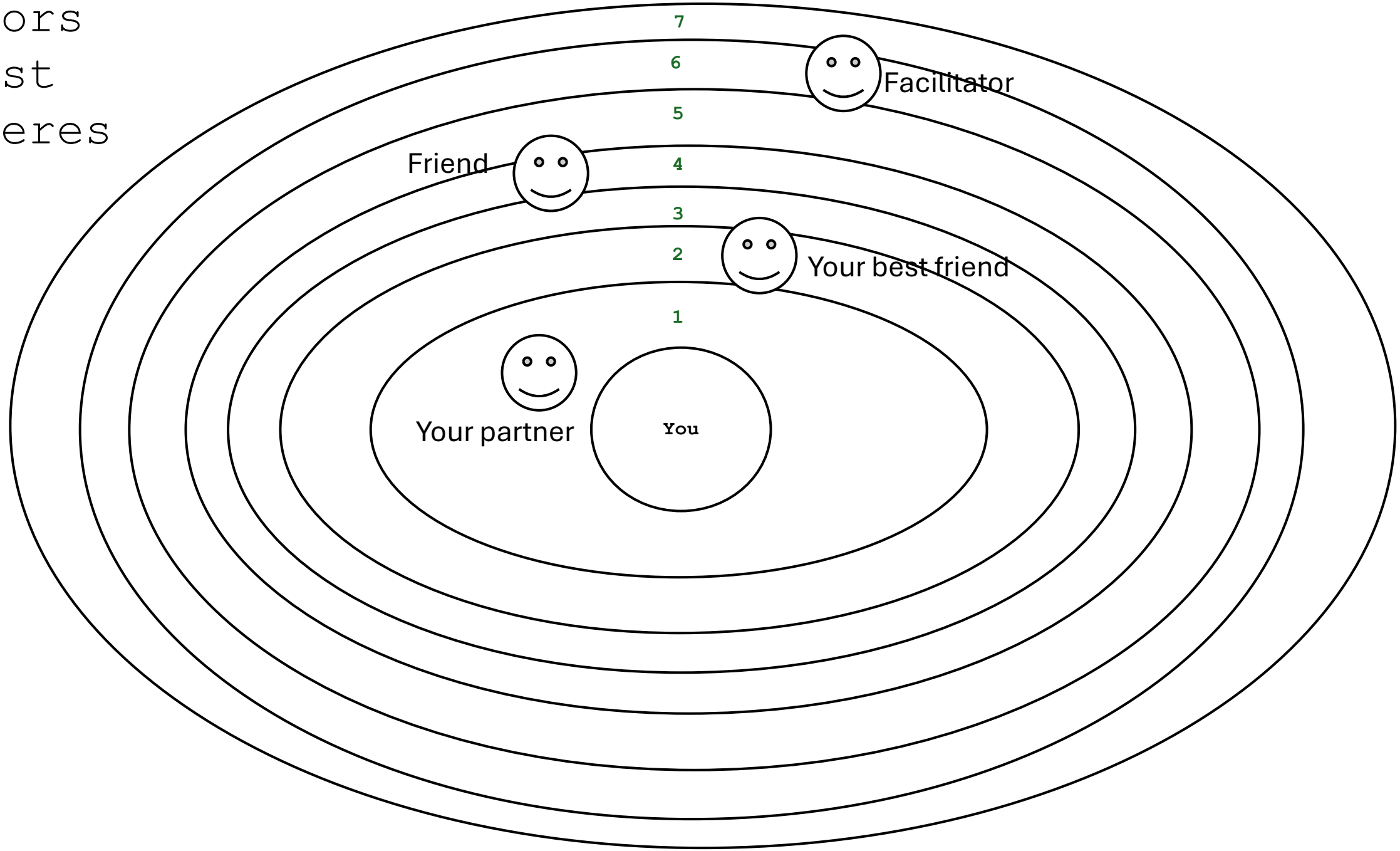
The Truth: These celebrities are victims of fake ads

- They're suing the platforms
- They never endorsed these products
- Always check the celebrity's official channels

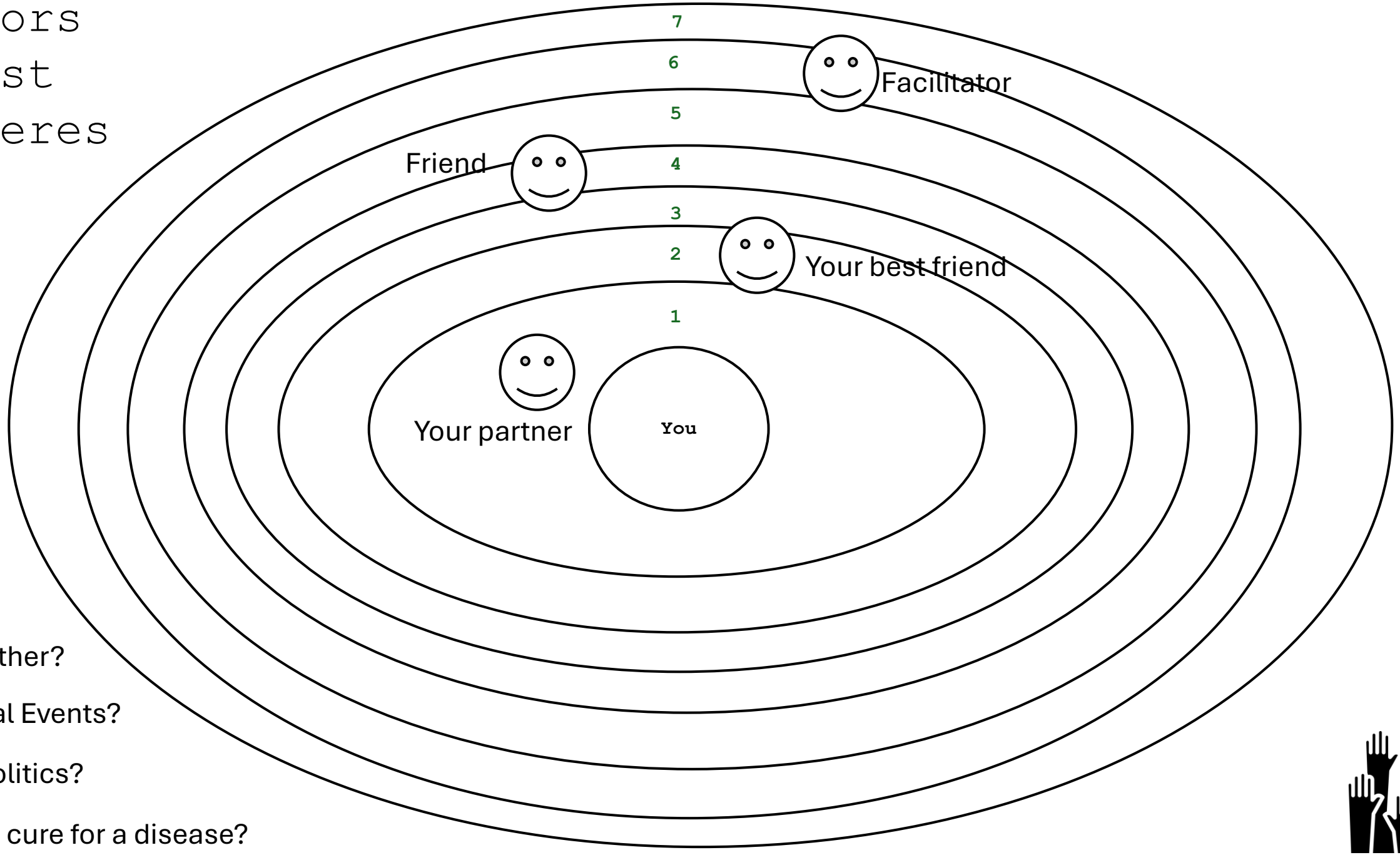
Skill 1: Stop, Question, Check, Decide

- When we are exposed to information, we are more likely to believe information depending on the relationship we have with them.
- Family members are typically the people we trust the most, because they are the people we are inherently closest to – assuming there hasn’t been something that has reduced the closeness of the relationship we share with our family.
- Then friends, co-workers, neighbours, so on.

Actors Trust Spheres



Actors Trust Spheres



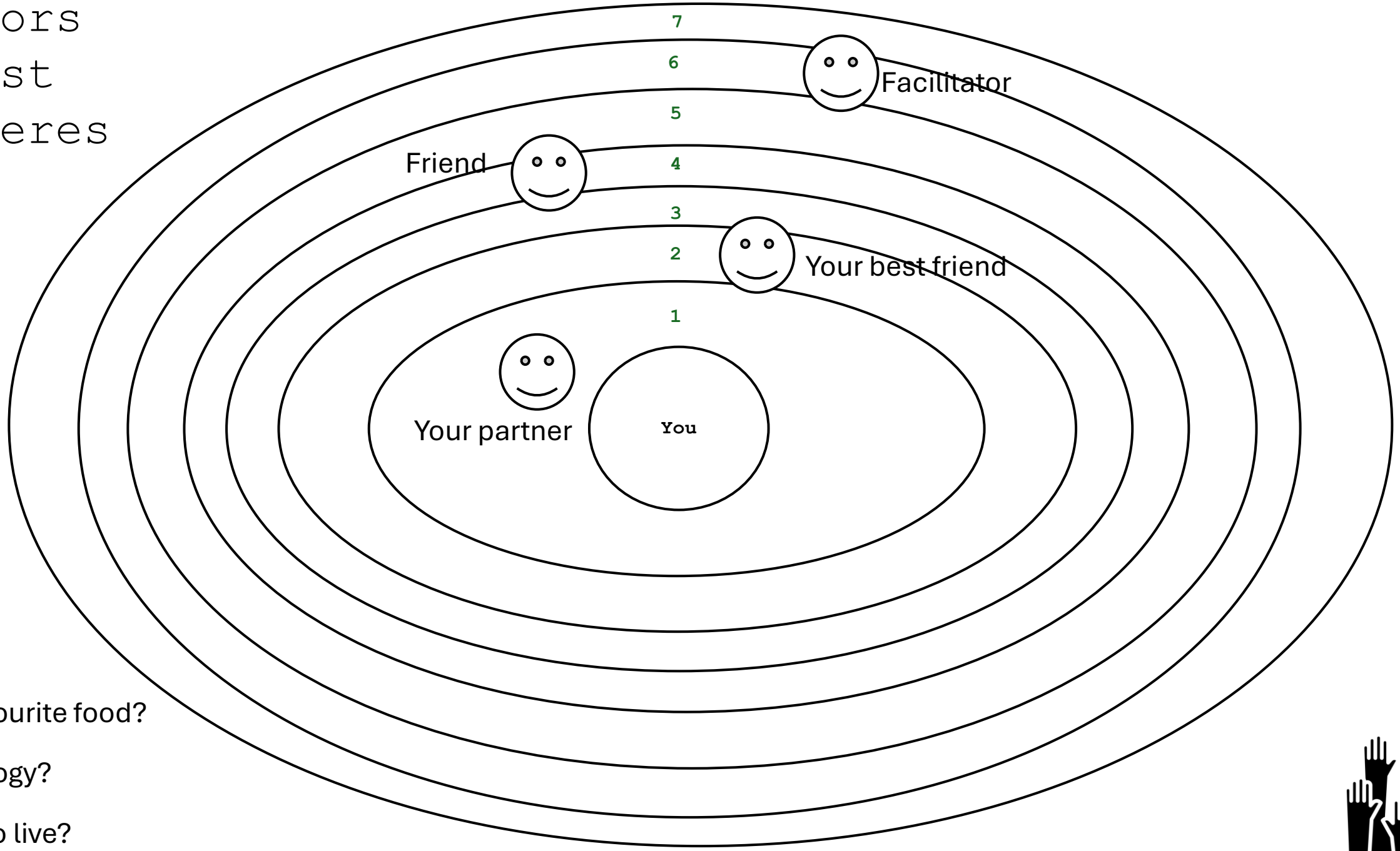
The weather?

The Local Events?

World politics?

The best cure for a disease?

Actors Trust Spheres

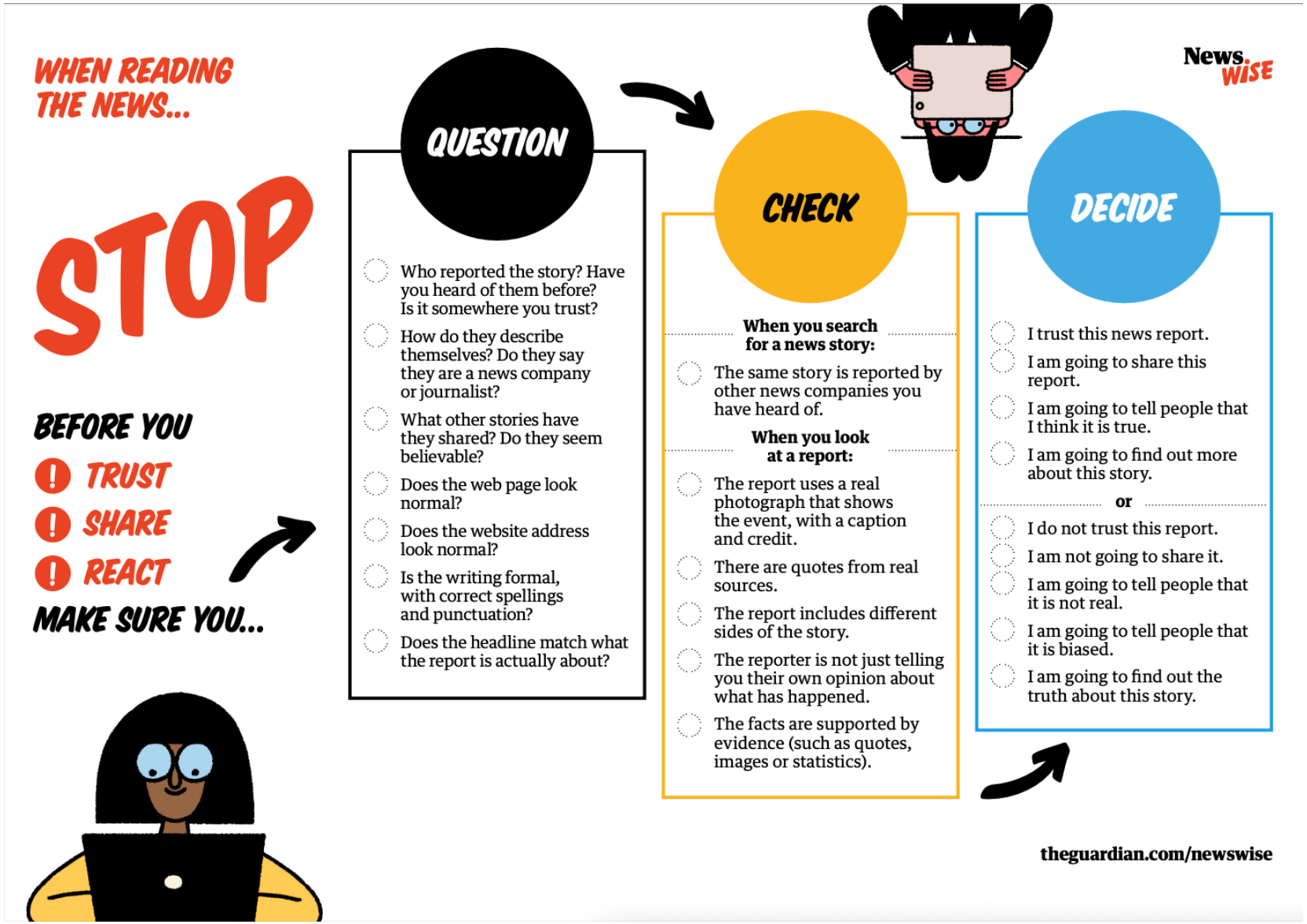


Sports?

Your favourite food?

Technology?

Where to live?



We'll look at 5 websites together and decide:

Trustworthy or not?

What are the clues?

Get out your handout and follow along!

BBC News Article

URL: https://www.bbc.co.uk/news/uk-politics-12345678
Headline: "Chancellor Announces New Budget Measures"
About the site:

- Official BBC website
- Has "About the BBC" section
- Author byline: "By James Landale, BBC Political Correspondent"
- Published date clearly shown
- Related articles from BBC News archive
- Standard BBC formatting

Breaking News Daily

URL: www.breakingnewsdaily.com.co
Headline: "SHOCKING: Royal Family Secret EXPOSED - Share Before Deleted!!!"
About the site:

- No "About Us" page
- No contact information
- No author name given
- Article says "sources say" but doesn't name them
- Multiple spelling errors
- Lots of popup ads
- Other headlines are all sensational

The Guardian

URL: https://www.theguardian.com/politics/2024/article-title
Headline: "Government faces criticism over housing policy"
About the site:

- Well-known national newspaper
- Clear "About Us" section
- Author: "Jane Smith, Social Affairs Correspondent"
- Article cites specific sources and quotes
- Related coverage from other journalists
- Contact details for newsroom

Gov-uk Pensions

URL: www.govuk-pensions.org
Headline: "Claim Your Pension Refund Now"
About the site:

- URL looks similar to government site but ends in .org
- Asks for personal information immediately
- "Limited time offer"
- Claims to be official government service
- Poor grammar: "Your entitled to refund"
- No official government logo or crown

Full Fact

URL: https://fullfact.org/health/vaccine-claim-debunked/
Headline: "Viral claim about vaccines is false"
About the site:

- Independent fact-checking organization
- Registered UK charity
- Clear methodology explained
- Sources and evidence linked
- About page with team information
- Contact details provided
- Checked by multiple fact-checkers

News WISE

WHEN READING THE NEWS...

STOP

QUESTION

CHECK

DECIDE

theguardian.com/newswise

Skill 1: Stop, Question, Check, Decide

Fact-Checking Like a Pro

Don’t take anything at face value!

Skill 2: Lateral reading

Don't Read Down, Read Across

Instead of: Reading the article top to bottom

Do this: Open new tabs and research the source first

Steps:

- See a claim or article
- Open a new tab
- Search for the website/author
- What do others say about them?
- Then decide if you should read the original

Skill 3: Reverse Image Searching

Pictures Can Lie

A photo might be:

- From a different event
- From years ago
- Photoshopped
- Taken out of context

How to Check:

- Right-click the image
- Select "Search image with Google"
- See where else it appears and when

Works on computers and smartphones!

Skill 4: Check the Date

Old News Recirculated

Common trick: Share old stories as if they're current

Always check:

- When was this published?
- Is the information still accurate?
- Why is it being shared now?
- Example: Old crime stories shared during election campaigns

Skill 5: Cross-Reference Multiple Sources

The Two-Source Rule

If it's real news:

- Multiple reputable outlets will report it
- They'll have similar facts (not identical wording)
- Look for 2-3 trusted sources confirming it

If only one unknown site reports it:

- Probably false or misleading

Skill 6: Look for Original Sources

Follow the Chain

Claims often say:

- "Studies show..."
- "Experts say..."
- "Reports indicate..."

Ask: Which study? Which experts? Which report?

Real journalism links to or names the original source

Common UK Misinformation Topics

Be Extra Careful With:

- NHS and health service claims
- Benefits and pension information
- Immigration statistics
- Crime rates
- Political claims (especially near elections)
- Royal family rumours

These topics attract the most misinformation

Red Flags in the Content

Warning Signs:

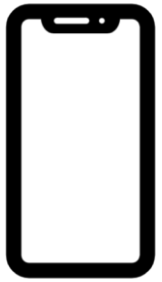
- ALL CAPS HEADLINES!!!
- Excessive exclamation marks!!!!
- "They don't want you to know this"
- "Share before it's deleted"
- Appeals to emotion over facts
- No evidence or sources provided
- Claims that seem too shocking to be true

Live Fact-Checking

We'll fact-check 3 real claims together:

- A health claim
- A political claim
- A viral social media story

Follow along with your device or watch the demonstration



Claim 1

The Claim: "New study proves that drinking 8 glasses of water a day is actually dangerous for your kidneys. Doctors have been lying to us for years! Share this before Big Pharma takes it down."

Found on: Facebook post, shared 15,000 times

Your Investigation:

What needs checking?

- Is there a "new study"?
- What study? Where was it published?
- Do doctors actually recommend 8 glasses?
- Is water dangerous for kidneys?

Claim 1

- **Red flags in the claim:**
- "Doctors have been lying" (inflammatory language)
- "Big Pharma takes it down" (conspiracy language)
- No study named or linked
- Urges immediate sharing
- **What We Found:**
- **VERDICT:** FALSE / MISLEADING

The Facts:

- No credible study shows water is dangerous for healthy kidneys
- The "8 glasses" is a general guideline, not a strict rule
- NHS recommends 6-8 glasses for most people
- Water is essential for kidney function
- Very rare cases of water intoxication require excessive amounts
- **Source:** NHS website, Full Fact

Claim 2

The Claim: "The UK is taking in 1 million immigrants every year. That's 3,000 people every single day coming into our country. The government doesn't want you to know these figures!"

Found on: Twitter/X, widely shared in group chats

Your Investigation:

What needs checking?

- What are the actual immigration figures?
- What counts as "immigration"?
- Are these net or gross figures?
- Where do official statistics come from?

Claim 2

Red flags in the claim:

- "Government doesn't want you to know" (conspiracy framing)
- No source cited
- Round numbers (1 million exactly?)
- Emotional framing

What We Found:

VERDICT: MISLEADING (mixing different types of immigration)

The Facts:

- The numbers mix different types of migration
- Net migration (people coming minus people leaving) varies by year
- Recent years have seen higher numbers, but context matters
- Includes students (temporary), workers (various lengths), refugees, family reunification
- Official statistics are publicly available from ONS
- Not a secret - reported regularly by media

Important: Statistics need context

- How many people leave?
- How long do people stay?
- What categories of migration?

Source: Office for National Statistics, Full Fact, Migration Observatory

Claim 3

The Claim: "BREAKING: Martin Lewis says everyone should move their money out of high street banks NOW. He's recommending this little-known investment that banks don't want you to know about. Click here to see his video."

Found on: Facebook ad with Martin Lewis's photo

Your Investigation:

What needs checking?

- Did Martin Lewis actually say this?
- Is there a video?
- What is this "investment"?
- Would Martin Lewis really tell people to move all their money?

Claim 3

Red flags in the claim:

- Celebrity endorsement of investment
- "Banks don't want you to know"
- Pressure to act "NOW"
- Vague "little-known investment"
- "Click here" link

What We Found:

VERDICT: FALSE - This is a SCAM

The Facts:

- Martin Lewis DID NOT make this statement
- This is a fake advertisement using his image without permission
- Martin Lewis has sued Facebook/Meta multiple times over fake ads
- He regularly warns about these scams on his website
- The "investment" is typically a cryptocurrency or forex scam
- Martin Lewis never endorses specific investment products in ads

This is a common scam pattern:

- Use trusted celebrity face
- Create urgency
- Promise exclusive information
- Lead to fraudulent investment scheme

Source: MoneySavingExpert.com, Martin Lewis's Twitter, BBC News articles about his legal cases

Social Media and Scams

Protecting yourself online

How social media works

Understanding the Algorithm

- Social media shows you:
- Content you're likely to engage with (like, comment, share)
- NOT necessarily accurate content
- Content similar to what you've clicked before
- Beware of content that gets you angry (Rage baiting)

Result: You can end up in an "echo chamber"

- Seeing only one perspective
- Misinformation can spread in these bubbles

The WhatsApp Problem

Forwarded Messages

WhatsApp is a major source of misinformation because:

- Messages come from trusted friends/family
- No way to check the original source
- Easy to forward to multiple groups
- Private, so false claims aren't publicly debunked

Rule: Stop before you forward!

Spotting Fake Profiles

Warning Signs:

- Profile photo is a stock image or celebrity
- Very few friends/followers
- Account created recently
- Only shares political or controversial content
- Generic name (e.g., "UK Patriot 2024")
- Lots of posting but no personal content

Bots are automated accounts that spread misinformation at scale

Deepfakes

Manipulated Media

Technology now allows:

- Fake videos of people saying things they never said
- Realistic AI-generated images and video
- Voice cloning

Getting harder to spot, but:

- Is it from a trusted source?
- Are reputable news outlets reporting it?
- Does something seem "off" about it?

HMRC & Tax Scams

Extremely Common!

The Scam:

- Text, email, or call claiming to be from HMRC
- Says you're owed a tax refund
- Or you owe money and face arrest/prosecution
- Asks you to click a link or call back

The Truth:

- HMRC never asks for personal information via text/email
- They never threaten immediate arrest
- Refunds come through your tax return, not surprise texts

NHS Scams

Health Service Impersonation

Common scams:

- "Missed appointment" texts with fees
- Prescription delivery charges
- COVID-19 vaccine/test payments
- Health records "need updating"

The Truth:

- NHS never asks for payment via text links
- Prescriptions have set fees paid at pharmacy
- NHS appointments are free

Energy and Cost of Living Scams

Taking Advantage of Current Issues

Fake messages about:

- Energy bill rebates
- Cost-of-living payments
- Council tax refunds
- Warm home discounts

Always suspicious if:

- Asks for bank details
- Payment to claim rebate
- Comes via text/email (not official letter)

Check: www.gov.uk for real support schemes

Pension Scams

Targeting Your Savings

- Warning signs:
- Free pension review from unknown company
- Pressure to transfer pension quickly
- Overseas investment opportunities
- "Pension liberation" (accessing before 55)
- Returns that sound too good to be true

Protect yourself:

- Only deal with FCA-regulated firms
- Take your time
- Get independent financial advice
- Check the FCA Warning List

Royal Mail / Parcel Scams

Even I have fallen foul of these!

The Scam:

- Text saying parcel delivery attempted
- Small "redelivery fee" required (£1-3)
- Link looks official
- Actually steals your card details

Spot it:

- Royal Mail doesn't text about redelivery fees
- They leave a card if you're out
- Check tracking on official Royal Mail website only

Bank Impersonation Scams

These are sophisticated and dangerous.

The Call:

- Claims to be from your bank
- Says there's fraud on your account
- Asks you to "verify" details or move money to "safe account"
- Very professional, may know some of your details

Remember:

- Banks NEVER ask you to move money to "safe accounts"
- Banks NEVER ask for your full PIN or password
- If in doubt, hang up and call the number on your card

Romance Scams

Especially on Facebook

The Pattern:

- Profile of attractive person (often military/oil rig worker)
- Quick progression to love declarations
- Then: emergency need for money
- Excuses why they can't meet in person
- Asks you to keep relationship secret

Warning: If you haven't met them, don't send money

General Scam Red Flags

Trust Your Instincts

- 🚨 Urgency ("act now or lose out!”)
- 🚨 Too good to be true
- 🚨 Request for payment or personal details
- 🚨 Pressure or threats
- 🚨 Emotional manipulation
- 🚨 Poor spelling/grammar in "official" messages
- 🚨 Unusual payment methods (gift cards, cryptocurrency)

What to do if you’ve been Scammed

Don't Be Embarrassed - Act Fast

Immediately:

1. Contact your bank (freeze accounts/cards)
2. Report to Action Fraud: 0300 123 2040
3. Change passwords
4. Tell your family (they may be targeted too)

Then: 5. Report to the platform (Facebook, etc.) 6. Contact Citizens Advice if you need support 7. Learn from it - scammers are professional criminals

Where to Report Scams

Keep These Numbers Handy

Action Fraud

- 0300 123 2040
- www.actionfraud.police.uk
- UK's national fraud reporting centre

Citizens Advice Scams Action

- 0808 250 5050
- Free advice and support

Which? Scam Alert

- Sign up for email warnings about current scams

Social Media Privacy Settings

Take Control

Basic steps:

- Review who can see your posts (friends only?)
- Limit who can contact you
- Turn off location sharing
- Review app permissions
- Be careful what personal information is public

Activity: We'll review Facebook privacy settings together

Activity Time!

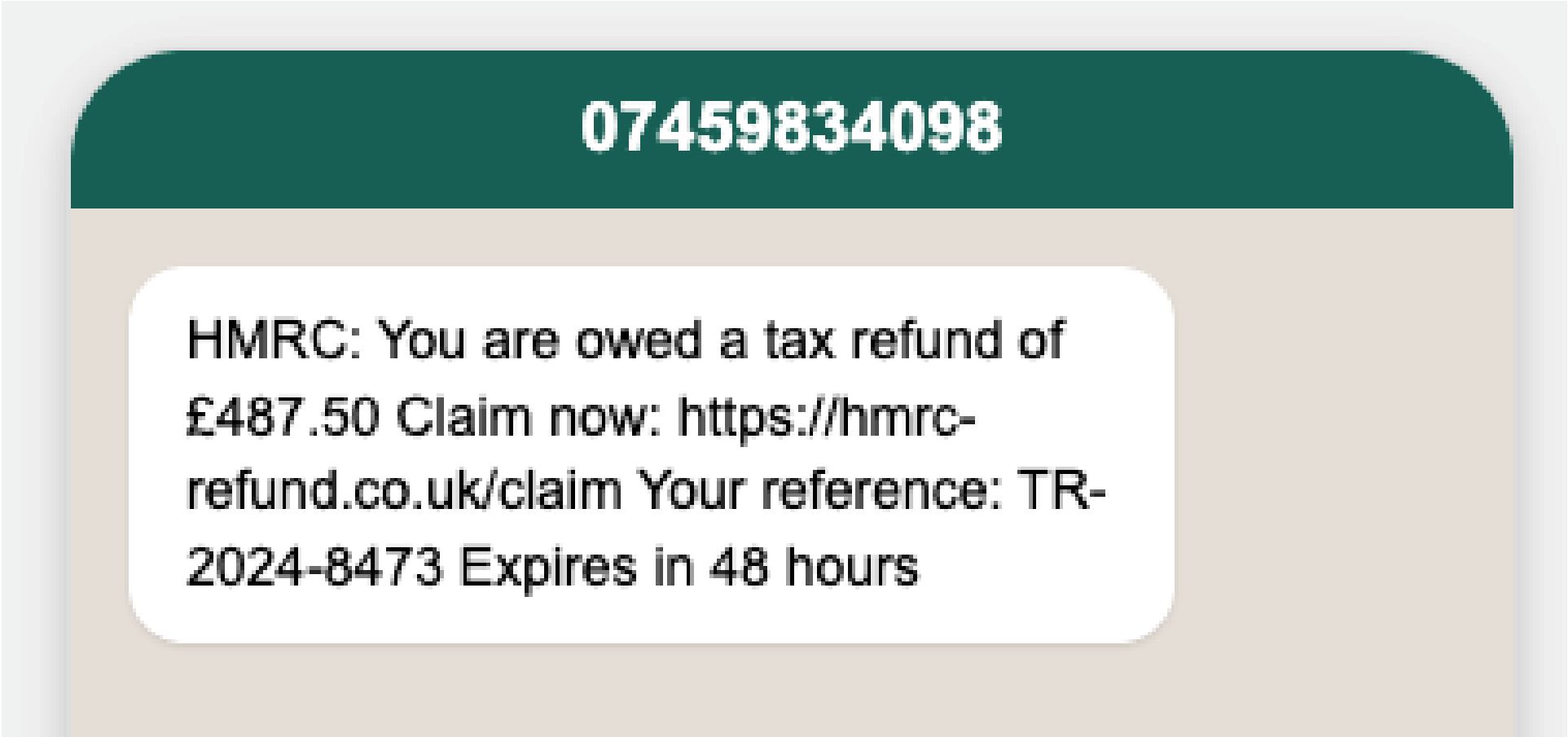
Spot the Scam

We'll look at some real examples:

- Texts
- Emails
- Which ones are scams? What are the clues?

Message 1

SCAM ❌



Message 2
LEGITIMATE ✓

Folders

Inbox

Sent

Drafts

Archive

Spam

Tags

Client
Internal
Invoice

Reply | Forward | •••

{{Timestamp: Nov 14, 2025 — 09:24}}

NHS notifications@nhs.uk

Mark unread

Archive

Your NHS Appointment Reminder

To: you@example.com • Nov 14, 2025, 09:24

Dear Patient,

This is a reminder that you have an appointment at:

St. Mary's Hospital
Date: 15th November 2024
Time: 10:30 AM
Department: Cardiology

If you need to cancel or reschedule, please call:
0161 234 5678

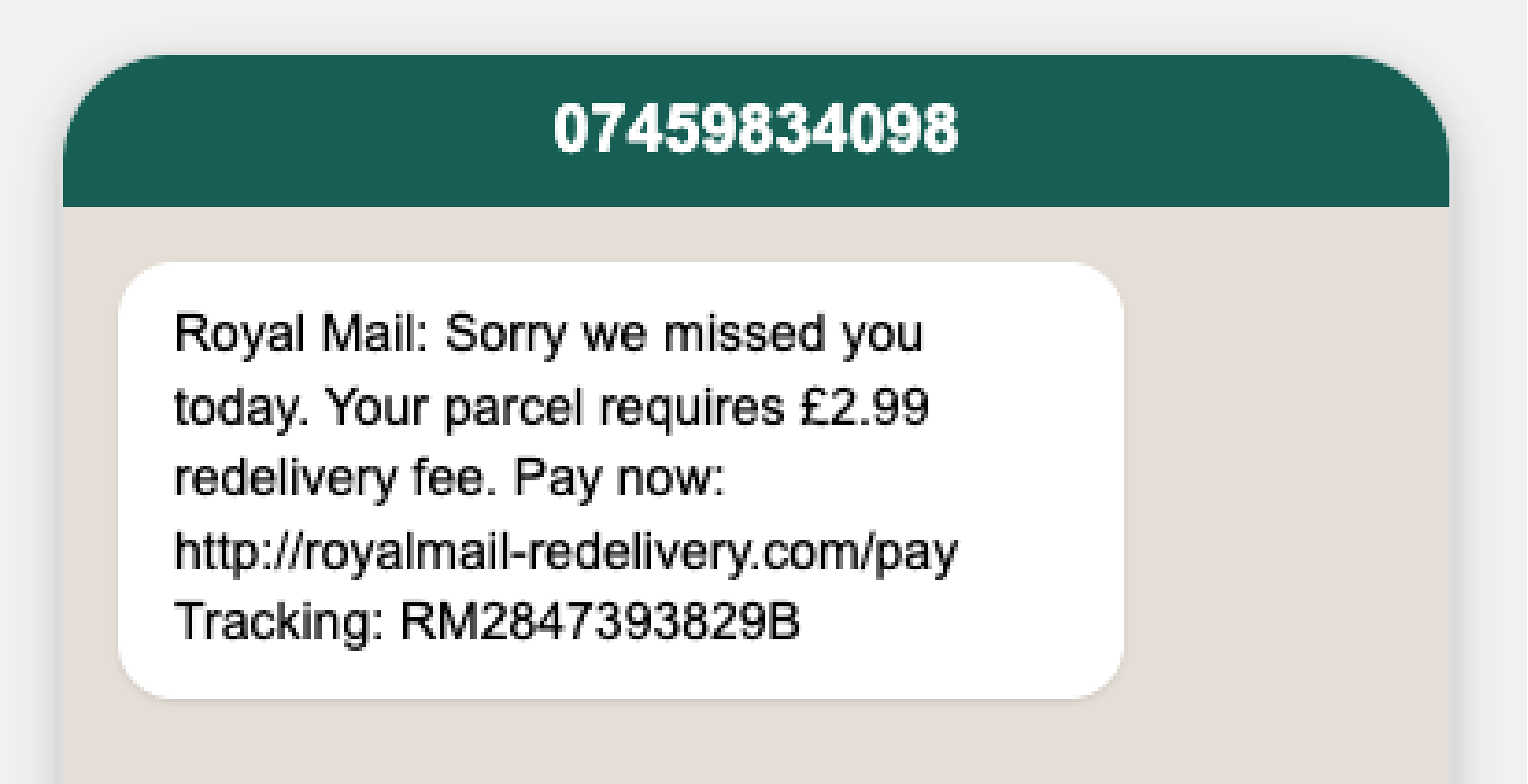
No reply needed to this email.

NHS England

Reply | Reply all | Forward

Message 3

SCAM ❌



Message 4

SCAM ❌

Folders

Inbox

Sent

Drafts

Archive

Spam

Tags

Client
Internal
Invoice

Reply | Forward | •••

{{Timestamp: Nov 14, 2025 — 09:24}}

Martin Lewis Martin.Lewis@moneysaving.com

Mark unread

Archive

URGENT: Move Your Money Now!

To: you@example.com • Nov 14, 2025, 09:24

Dear Friend,

I've discovered an investment opportunity that high street banks don't want you to know about. I've made £25,000 in just 3 weeks!

This Bitcoin platform is revolutionary. Sign up now using my special link before spots run out:

[Click here to join]

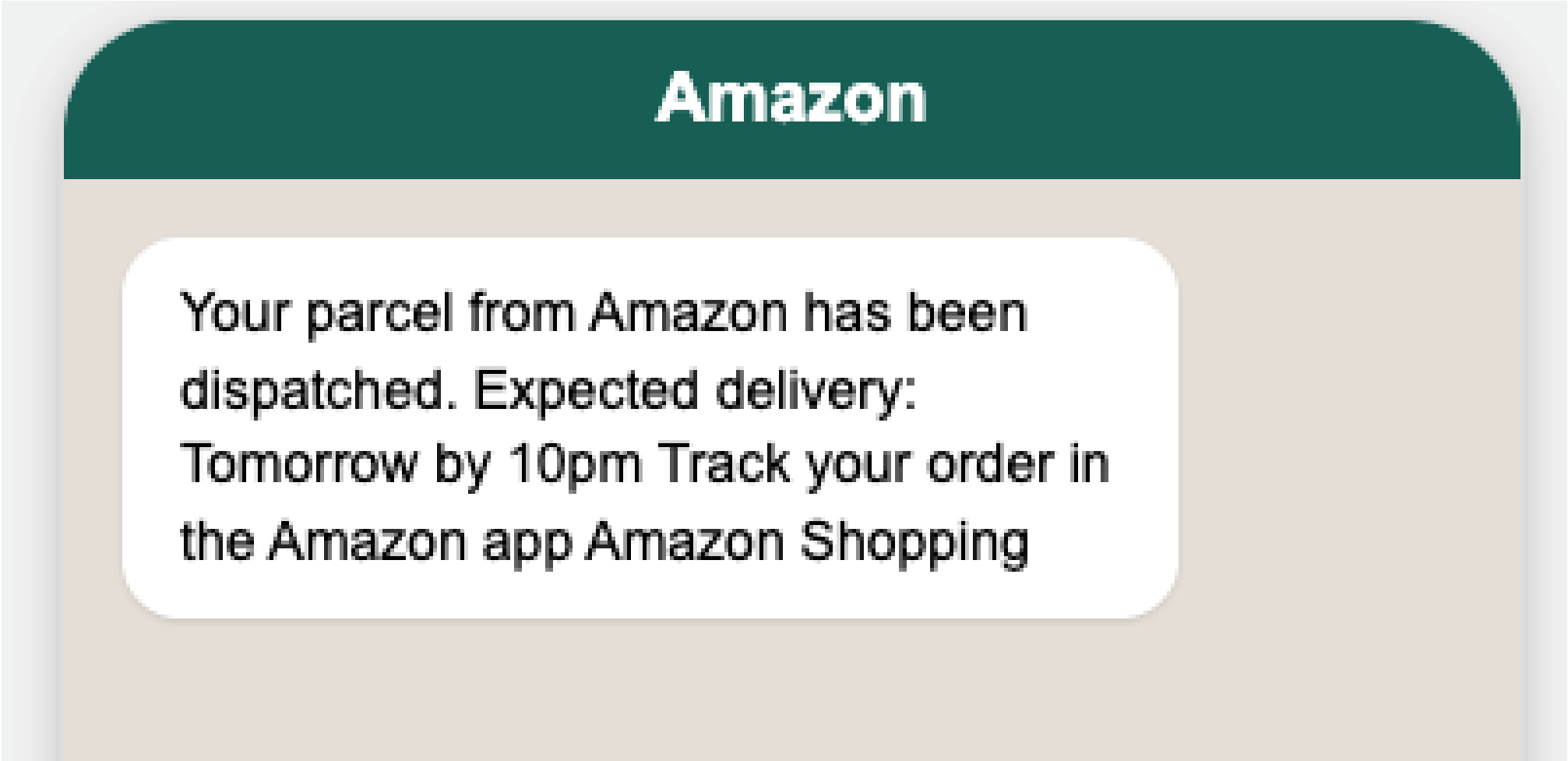
Don't miss this chance!

Martin Lewis
Money Saving Expert

Reply | Reply all | Forward

Message 5

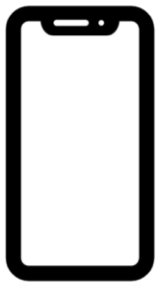
LEGITIMATE ✓



Message 6

SCAM ❌

"This is a message from HMRC Tax Office. We have identified a serious tax fraud case under your name. If we don't hear from you immediately, a warrant will be issued for your arrest. Press 1 to speak to an officer or call back on 020-7946-0123."



Message 7

SCAM ❌

Folders

Inbox

Sent

Drafts

Archive

Spam

Tags

Client
Internal
Invoice

Reply | Forward | •••

{{Timestamp: Nov 14, 2025 — 09:24}}

Gov UK support@energy-help.gov.uk

Mark unread

Archive

URGENT: Move Your Money Now!

To: you@example.com • Nov 14, 2025, 09:24

You are eligible for the £400 Energy Bill Support payment.

To receive your payment, verify your details:
- Full name
- Address
- Bank account number and sort code

Click here: energy-rebate-claim.co.uk

Energy Support Team
UK Government

Reply | Reply all | Forward

Your Action Plan

Building better habits

What have we learned so far?

- Skill 1: Stop, Question, Check, Decide
- Skill 2: Lateral reading
- Skill 3: Reverse Image Searching
- Skill 4: Check the Date
- Skill 5: Cross-reference multiple sources
- Skill 6: Look for Original Sources

- What is misinformation, disinformation, fake news
- The difference between bias and accuracy
- How to spot fake news
- How to conduct fact checking and cross referencing
- How to spot scams
- Different type of scams
- What to do if you have been scammed

- Skill 7: Recognising scam texts and emails

Before you share – STOP – The 3-step check

STOP

Don’t share immediately!

Especially if it makes you angry, scared or excited.

Emotional content spreads fastest.

CHECK

Is the source trustworthy?

Can you verify it?

What do our fact checking websites say?

THINK

Could this harm someone?

What if it *was* false?

Would I want someone to check before sharing this?

Responding to false information

- Challenging misinformation can be difficult
  - Are you close to them?
  - Are you sure you are right?
  - Is it worth it?
  - Would it damage the relationship?
  - Could the misinformation cause harm?
  - How misinformed are they?
  - How emotional are you?
  - Are you equipped to have the conversation?

Correcting false information

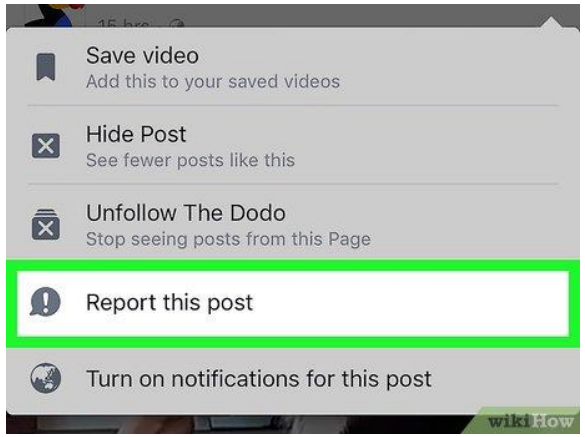
Do’s

✓ Be kind and respectful
✓ Ask questions ("Where did you see this?")
✓ Share fact-checking links
✓ Explain why it matters
✓ Use private messages for family
✓ Educate them rather than challenging them
✓ Accept that sometimes minds can’t be changed

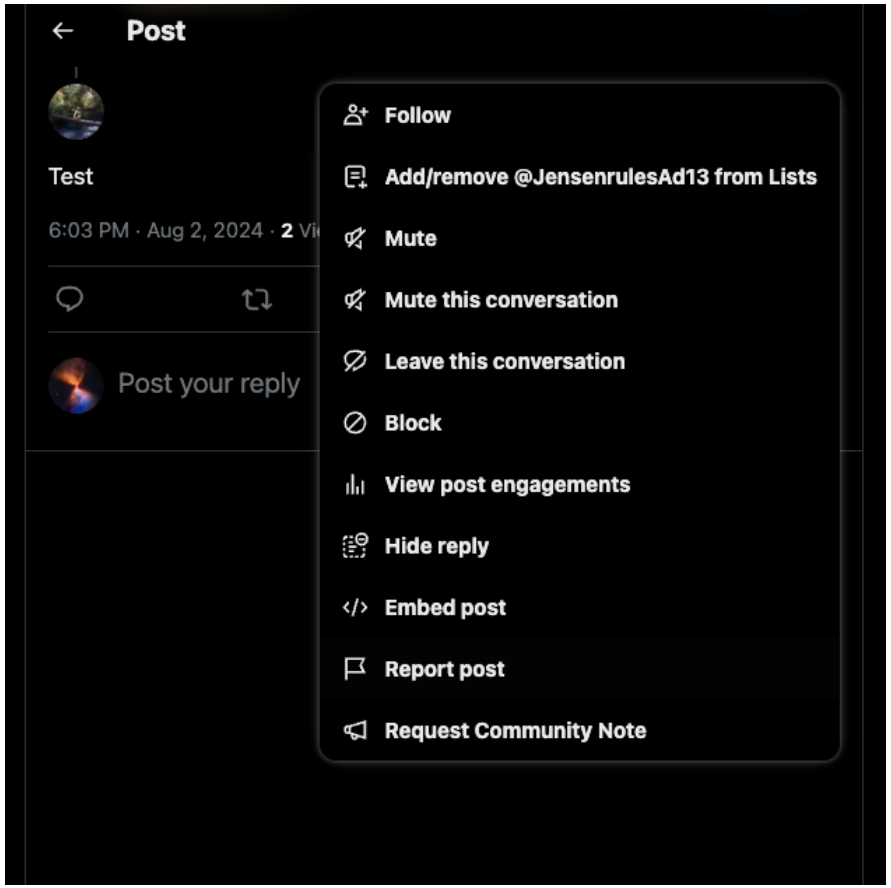
Don’ts

✗ Use others you know for support (spreads it further)
✗ Be condescending ("How could you believe that?")
✗ Share the false claim to debunk it (spreads it further)
✗ Get into public arguments
✗ Expect to change minds immediately

Reporting false content



Facebook



X (Twitter)

WhatsApp

Building Better Habits

Your Daily Information Diet:

- ✓ Follow trusted UK sources directly
- ✓ Read full articles, not just headlines
- ✓ Diversify your sources (different perspectives)
- ✓ Be sceptical of shocking claims
- ✓ Check before you share
- ✓ Take breaks from social media
- ✓ Talk to family about what you've learned

Trusted Sources to Follow

Build Your Feed

News Apps to Download:

- BBC News
- Sky News
- ITV News
- Channel 4 News

Fact-Checking:

- Full Fact
- BBC Reality Check

Scam Alerts:

- Which? (sign up for Scam Alert emails)
- Action Fraud updates

Your Take-Home Toolkit

Remember These 5 Things

- **Check the source** before believing or sharing
- **Use Full Fact** when in doubt
- **Banks never ask you to move money** to "safe accounts"
- **STOP before you share** emotional content
- **Report scams** to Action Fraud immediately